Norway Loses Its World Juniors Spot to Russia, but the Story Isn't Over

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Norway's young hockey players may have lost their place at the world junior **championships** before the **tournament** even starts. The Norwegian Ice Hockey Association said on Sunday that it has been told Norway is being bumped so Russia can take part instead.

The switch follows a recent ruling by the Court of Arbitration for Sport, which **reinstated** Russian hockey teams to international competition, starting with the world juniors. The **tournament** for the best male players under 20 opens in Alberta, Canada, on December 26, with ten nations taking part.

But the decision has not been formally announced by the International Ice Hockey Federation, and its website still lists Norway as a participant. Norway, ranked tenth going into the **tournament**, said it was moved down to the 1A Division to open the spot for Russia.

Russia is not guaranteed to play, either. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney has said he will bar the Russian team from entering Canada, which could leave the door open for Norway after all.

'The situation is still unclear,' said Norway's ice hockey secretary general, Peter Salsten. 'This makes us hope that the last word has not been said about our participation in Canada.'

There are more complications. Six nations, including Norway, have vowed to **boycott** games against Russia as long as the war in Ukraine continues. Several longtime **sponsors** have also said they will drop out if Russia plays.

Russia has not competed in the **tournament** since finishing fourth in 2021. Its teams were banned after the country invaded Ukraine in February 2022. Norway said it understands that the court ruling has tied the IIHF's hands, but Salsten added that the situation 'clearly shows all the practical challenges and immediate consequences for everyone involved when countries are **reinstated** immediately.'

Word Treasure

reinstated -- Brought back, or allowed to take part again after being kept out.

boycott -- To refuse to take part in something as a protest.

tournament -- A contest where teams play a series of games to find a winner.

sponsors -- Companies that pay money to support an event, usually in return for advertising.

championships -- Big contests to decide who is the best in a sport.

Background you need

The world junior championships are a big international hockey tournament for the best male players under 20, with ten nations taking part.

Russian teams were banned from the tournament after Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022, and Russia has not played since finishing fourth in 2021.

The Court of Arbitration for Sport is a court that settles disputes in sport, and its ruling let Russian teams return.

Because the tournament is in Canada, the Canadian government can decide which teams may enter the country, which is why Norway's hopes are still alive.

Break it down

LEAD: Norway says it is being bumped from the world juniors so Russia can play instead.

KEY EVENT: A sports court ruling reinstated Russian teams, and Norway was moved down to the 1A Division.

+- WHO: Norway's hockey association, Russia, the International Ice Hockey Federation and Canada's prime minister.

+- WHEN: The tournament opens on December 26 in Alberta, Canada.

EVIDENCE: The federation has not formally announced the change, and its website still lists Norway.

OPEN QUESTION: Will Canada bar the Russian team, leaving the door open for Norway?

Why it matters

Sport and world events are connected: this story shows how a war far away can change who gets to play in a youth tournament, and how countries and sponsors use their choices to take a stand.

Test what you remember

1. Why is Norway losing its place at the world juniors?

(A) Because Norway lost a game
(B) Because Norway has too few players
(C) Because the tournament was cancelled
(D) To make room for Russia

2. Which court ruled that Russian teams could return to international play?

(A) The Supreme Court of Canada
(B) The Court of Arbitration for Sport
(C) The Norwegian Ice Hockey Association
(D) The International Ice Hockey Federation

3. When does the tournament open?

(A) November 9
(B) February 2022
(C) December 26
(D) January 10

4. What has Canada's prime minister said he will do?

(A) He will ban all hockey in Canada
(B) He will move the tournament to Norway
(C) He will bar the Russian team from entering Canada
(D) He will pay for Norway's trip

5. How many nations have vowed to boycott games against Russia?

(A) Six
(B) Ten
(C) Four
(D) Two

6. When did Russia last play in the tournament?

(A) 2020
(B) 2022
(C) 2019
(D) 2021

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Norway's ice hockey association: It hopes the last word has not been said and that Norway may still take part, while understanding that the court ruling has tied the federation's hands.

2. The six boycotting nations: They have vowed not to play games against Russia as long as the war in Ukraine continues.

3. Longtime sponsors: Several have said they will drop out if Russia plays.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):